History of Police Canine Programs

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Abstract

This research paper goes over the history of police canine programs in the United States. It begins with discussing the training programs that originated in Ghent, Belgium and their subsequent spread to police departments in the United States. While canine programs throughout the United States exploded in popularity, these programs were met with mixed success. Poor training methods coupled with legal issues resulted in a lot of programs ending prematurely. Despite mixed results, dogs' roles within law enforcement have expanded tremendously, from tracking suspects, search-and-rescue, evidence retrieval, to bomb sniffing. This paper will trace how these roles came about and how they've continued to aid law enforcement. It will also discuss the controversy around some of those roles and the legal trouble that has arisen because of them. Dogs have been instrumental to many different human industries, and understanding the history and context of how our nation has used them for law enforcement is necessary for determining how best they should be used in the future.

Keywords: canine, law enforcement, K-9 unit, historical analysis, police dog

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For almost all of written history, humans have relied upon dogs for protection, companionship, and hunting. But in modern times their roles have expanded, what started as mere roles as guards has grown into countless roles in all facets of human industry. This is especially true in the field of law enforcement. While it is arguable that dogs have existed as aids to law enforcement for centuries as security detail, it is only in recent history that there have been official programs for training police dogs (Handy et al., 1961). According to Chapman (1990), the first formal police dog training program began in the late 19th century in Ghent, Belgium. The program became well known for its success in canine training and breeding programs. By 1907 states Chapman (1990), Police stations in America sought to match the success of the Belgian program by purchasing some of their highly trained dogs, thus establishing the first police canine programs in North America. However, the demand did not stop there, soon every police station sought to establish their own program. By 1979 states Chapman (1990), more than over 700 police canine programs had been attempted in the United States alone. Unfortunately, many of those programs failed due to poor planning, mismanagement, and the challenges of maintaining a canine program (Chapman, 1990). Over the past century these programs have existed, law enforcement agencies have adapted and diversified how they use their canine programs. What started as a tool for patrolling and apprehending suspects has expanded into search-and-rescue, bomb-detection, and evidence retrieval, saving police an untold number of man-hours (Chapman, 1990). Police canine programs have truly become a necessary part of modern law enforcement. Despite facing controversy and criticism, as well as legal and logistical issues these programs have brought over legal and logistical difficulties, police canine programs remain as a key part to nearly all parts of law enforcement.

For millennia, dogs have stood alongside humans as both companions and as co-laborers. In that time, they have served mankind in many different capacities: guards, shepherds, warriors, trackers, and hunters. In more recent times, dogs have taken up a new role in law enforcement (Chapman, 1990). While dogs have served in law enforcement throughout history in some capacity, it was primarily to guard property and royalty, not serve alongside officers (Handy et al., 1961).

The first program to specifically train canines for the purpose of law enforcement explains Chapman (1990), began in Ghent, Belgium in the late 19th century. Handy et al. (1961) explains that the key to the program's success was that they not only trained the dog, but also they trained the dog handler. This training practice was revolutionary because the officer and the dog were trained as partners, the dog was not simply a tool for the officer to use. It was the effectiveness of this program that caught the eye of police departments in America (Handy et al., 1961).

In 1907, the police departments of South Orange, New Jersey and New York, New York implemented the first American police canine programs with the dogs they received from Ghent (Chapman, 1990). These early police canines were trained to chase and capture suspects. According to Chapman (1990), this training began by conditioning the dogs to be aggressive towards individuals not wearing a police uniform. To capture suspects, the dogs were taught to wrap their front legs around a fleeing individual's legs, tripping them and holding them holding them down until canine officer could catch up. It was reported by newspapers at the time, says Chapman (1990), that within the first year of the New York canine unit being deployed crime had dropped 50% in the areas patrolled by the unit and within four years they stopped altogether. It

was these incredible claims of success that lead many other police departments across the United States to also adopt their own canine police program (Chapman, 1990).

The success of the programs in New York and South Orange inspired other departments to start their own. By 1952, there had been a total of fourteen attempted police canine programs in the United States (Chapman, 1990). According to Chapman (1990), excluding one program in Berkeley California, all of these canine programs were located in the Northeastern United States. Despite the alleged success of these programs, only three of the fourteen programs were operational by 1957 (Chapman, 1990). However, in only two years, thirty-eight police canine programs were started between 1958 and 1959 Chapman (1990). That is more than double the number of programs that were started in the first 50 years of the same century. Within the next two decades after that the fad only grew, Chapman (1990) states that by 1979 there had been over 750 police canine programs started in North America. While no specific reason explains why there was a sudden increase in police canine programs, it had clearly become a widespread trend for police departments.

Unfortunately, when organizations hastily follow trends, success is not guaranteed. As Chapman (1990) explains, many police departments that established canine programs at that time could provide no evidence to justify their need for a police canine program. Without research into how a police canine program could genuinely aid their department, many canine programs ended within the same decade they began (Handy et al., 1990). According to Chapman (1990), the primary reasons for ending police canine programs included poor financial planning, lack of planning for roles the dogs should fill, and poor training of both the dogs and their handlers. Additionally, many programs were discontinued simply due to the death or retirement of a canine

or handler without any replacement plan in place (Handy et al., 1961). These issues inevitably led to departmental inefficiency, injury, and poor publicity (Hoyt, 2024).

Over the past century, police canine programs have expanded and evolved to meet changing needs. One important role that has grown over the years is tracking. Police have historically used breeds like bloodhounds and German shepherds to track suspects, criminals, victims, and bodies (Chapman, 1990). The US and other governments have attempted to train other animals for the purpose of tracking, such as rodents, pigs, and even mongooses, but as Chapman (1990) explains, the standard choice is still the canine due to the versatility they provide beyond tracking.

Another role that has grown for police dogs is in drug and narcotics detection. The US government's War on Drugs in the 1970's led to numerous canines being deployed by the US government to work the nations land and sea borders in an attempt to catch drugs and narcotics entering the country (Chapman, 1990). These kinds of canine programs are able to justify themselves financially over other kinds of programs due to the high value of the evidence they detect. In 1989, Chapman (1990) states that the canine narcotics detection program employed by the US Border Patrol seized over $100,000,000 in dollars' worth of narcotics and $1,000,000 in cash.

Chapman (1990) explains that the 1970's also saw a rise in the amount of domestic terrorist bombings, which drastically increased the need for canine explosive detection programs. The increase in bomb threats to schools, banks, factories, and government buildings put an incredible strain on police departments. Chapman (1990) states that a bomb threat call typically required the entire department to respond. However, a specially trained explosive detection unit could accomplish what took an entire department to do in a fraction of the time (Chapman,

1990). This increase of domestic terrorism in the 70's also prompted the United States secret service to increase their use in explosive detection dogs. Chapman (1990) explains that the dogs were primarily used to clear the meeting spaces and boardrooms that were planned for use by the President, government officials, and visiting world leaders.

In conclusion, what started as a humble role of patrolling the streets of New York City grew into ensuring the protection of our nation's highest offices. Dogs have long worked alongside humans, but as Handy et al. (1961) states, the 19th and 20th century police canine programs showed society a new way for how they could serve. While the success of these programs led to them becoming incredibly popular all across America, they weren't full proof. Police departments often started canine programs without doing the proper research needed to access the need for one, leading canine units to end prematurely Chapman (1990). Despite this, dogs proved to be an essential part of law enforcement. Whatever was required of them, be it search and rescue, narcotic detection, or explosives detection, dogs always rose up to the occasion.

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